



Used Car Buyer Checklist

A high-level walkaround and test-drive guide before you hand over money.

WALKAROUND AND DRIVE

BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ Ask for the VIN, mileage, title status, and known issues before meeting.
- ☐ Request service records, recent repairs, and any inspection or emissions paperwork.
- ☐ Bring a flashlight, paper towel, tire gauge, and an OBD scanner if you have one.
- ☐ Plan to see the car in daylight and test drive it long enough to get fully warm.

EXTERIOR

- ☐ Walk around slowly and look for mismatched paint, overspray, dents, rust, or uneven gaps.
- ☐ Check windshield, mirrors, lights, signals, brake lights, and wipers.
- ☐ Look under the car for active leaks, hanging parts, heavy corrosion, or fresh damage.
- ☐ Open and close the hood, trunk, and every door. They should latch cleanly.

TIRES AND BRAKES

- ☐ All four tires should be the same size and preferably a matching brand/model.
- ☐ Look for uneven tire wear, cracking, bubbles, or very old date codes.
- ☐ During braking, the car should stop smoothly without grinding, pulsing, or pulling.
- ☐ Make sure the parking brake holds and releases normally.

INTERIOR

- ☐ Confirm warning lights turn on at startup, then turn off after the engine starts.
- ☐ Test windows, locks, mirrors, seats, gauges, infotainment, heat, and air conditioning.
- ☐ Check for damp carpet, mildew, heavy air freshener, or signs of water intrusion.
- ☐ Seatbelts, airbags, child-seat anchors, and basic safety equipment should be intact.

UNDER HOOD

- ☐ Look for obvious leaks, cracked hoses, loose wiring, corrosion, or missing covers.
- ☐ Check visible fluid levels and colors only when it is safe to do so.
- ☐ Listen for rough idle, knocking, squealing, ticking, or cooling fans running constantly.
- ☐ After the drive, confirm the car does not overheat or smell like coolant, oil, or fuel.

TEST DRIVE

- ☐ The car should start cold without long cranking, smoke, or unstable idle.
- ☐ Steering should feel straight and predictable, with no shake or wandering.
- ☐ Transmission shifts should feel clean. Manual clutch engagement should be consistent.
- ☐ Suspension should feel controlled over bumps without clunks, rattles, or harsh pulling.
- ☐ Try city speeds, highway speeds, parking-lot turns, reverse, and a safe full stop.



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PAPERWORK AND DECISION

PAPERWORK

- ☐ VIN should match the title, dashboard, door sticker, and any seller-provided documents.
- ☐ Seller name should match the title or have proper dealer/agent paperwork.
- ☐ Ask about liens, rebuilt or salvage history, accidents, flood damage, and lemon-law history.
- ☐ Budget taxes, registration, tires, brakes, fluids, inspection, and immediate repairs.

REASONS TO PAUSE

- ☐ Seller rushes you, refuses inspection, will not provide VIN, or changes the story.
- ☐ Title status is unclear, VIN plates look altered, or paperwork does not line up.
- ☐ The car has warning lights, overheating, unsafe tires, brake issues, or active leaks.
- ☐ The price only makes sense if you ignore obvious repairs.

Overall Status

Circle one, then add notes before you decide.

- ☐ Good candidate
- ☐ Needs inspection
- ☐ Walk away

Repair risk

- ☐ Low
- ☐ Medium
- ☐ High

Quick Details

VEHICLE Year / make / model / trim

VIN Copy from dash or door sticker

MILEAGE Odometer reading

ASKING PRICE Seller price

SELLER Name and contact

Future Mirage Hardware Scan

The long-term Mirage workflow adds a plug-in scan and buyer report: live data, alerts, drive notes, and a clearer health snapshot before a purchase. For now, this checklist stays visual and high level.

Final Notes